

the smartphone unusable for those few seconds. Now, while this is good in terms of scanning new apps for viruses, it could be happening in the background. But it's not all bad. While bloatware and app permissions are there for a larger reason like business and compliances, there are features in Xiaomi's software that I'm a big fan of. Firstly, the app clone feature which allows users to have two versions of the same app, if the said app supports the app clone feature. There is also the hibernation mode which is something I strongly believe should be there in every smartphone. What it does is, that when your smartphone's battery dies, the Xiaomi 14 squeezes out one percent of the battery to only keep the necessary things like calling on so that users are never without their smartphones. Smart.

CAMERA

Coming to the most important part of this review. Camera. The Xiaomi 14 is the second smartphone that the Chinese manufacturer is launching with the Leica partnership. So here, we get a triple rear camera setup with a 50-megapixel primary shooter with Leica Summicron certification, there is a 50-megapixel ultrawide angle lens, and another 50-megapixel telephoto shooter. Like last year's Xiaomi 13 Pro, with the Xiaomi 14 also we get a two main colour profiles - Leica authentic and Leica Vibrant, both obviously tuned by Leica.

Now, the number of camera features on this smartphone remind me of my recent review of the Vivo X100 Pro. There are so many things to talk about here that it is tough to even think where to begin with. The Xiaomi 14 is obviously a camera beast. The images from the primary shooter are very good, we get up to 3.2x optical zoom as well, so there is enough room to adjust your perspective also if you're wanting to unleash your inner photographer with the Xiaomi 14.

The performance is good. The images are sharp and detailed, and the dynamic range is also very good. With the level of hardware this smartphone has, I believe that the tuning is not the best and could be better, but the results are mostly very

aesthetic and balanced from the primary shooter. Even in low light the images are good. The smartphone has a large sensor that lets in enough light to never miss out on details, even in low light conditions. Of course, if you are in a pitch black environment with no source of light anywhere close, then no camera will be able to give any results, but in the Night mode the Xiaomi 14 does show things that aren't visible normally so I guess that's good since the camera is taking light from whatever little source possible.

The wide angle lens is also good, and the best part about it is that there is little to no difference between the quality of the images from the primary shooter as compared to the wide angle shooter. The results are consistent.

Coming to portraits, I'm quite impressed by how the portrait modes tuned by Leica perform. Not only does the smartphone get the edge detection and background blur right, the skin tones and various effects from Leica make portraits look really good. On the Xiaomi 14, we get 5 portrait presets, each of them set at a different focal length. From 35mm to 90mm, there are different focal lengths that you can choose from.

The only issue here is that each of these focal lengths have their own unique effect and there is no way to use each of these focal lengths without the effects in place. Further, the 90mm focal length on the Xiaomi 14 is set to the "Leica soft focus" effect, which is not my favourite since the photos look a little like they are out of focus. Yes, I'm aware that this is how it's meant to look, but here it would have been nice to have the 90mm focal length with a sharper focus on the subject.

So the camera is brilliant on the Xiaomi 14. Of course, having Leica back the camera development does make this one of the best cameras on Android right now, but a little bit of fine tuning is still required. The one thing I really wish Xiaomi thought of is to have the preset focal lengths, but without the preset effects.

BATTERY AND CHARGING

Coming to battery, since this is a small and compact flagship, Xiaomi has put a

4,610mAh battery on the Xiaomi 14. We also get 90W wired charging with PD 3.0, along with 50W fast wireless charging.

The battery backup on the Xiaomi 14 is decent. For example, playing Call of Duty: Mobile for 15 minutes on the highest graphics only drained 4 percent of the smartphone's battery. Watching a YouTube video on 2160p with HDR on high brightness drained 3 percent of the battery, and navigating using GPS for an hour straight drained 6 percent of the Xiaomi 14's battery. Charging is also fast. The smartphone comes with 90W fast charging, which took 44 minutes to charge the smartphone fully from dead so that is proper speed. We also get 50W wireless charging but I wasn't able to test it since the fast charger that I use maxes out at 15W output.

VERDICT

So that was the Xiaomi 14. From the moment I set my hands on this smartphone I had loved the design and the in-hand feel. Pair that with bleeding edge specs like the Snapdragon 8 Gen 3 chip with 16GB RAM or super fast wired and wireless charging, and I am sold. To make things sweeter, Xiaomi has also thrown in its camera expertise, thanks to the partnership with Leica.

So yes, there is very little to not like about the Xiaomi 14. The only thing that doesn't match up to the competition in any sense is the display's colour accuracy, which is surprisingly lower than many mid-range smartphones of 2024 also, but it can't be called bad at the same time. Further, the software has a couple of annoyances, but overall I am very happy to have another compact flagship in the market.

—Darab Mansoor Ali

SPECIFICATIONS

Octa core (3.3 GHz, Single Core + 3.2 GHz, Penta Core + 2.3 GHz, Dual core), Snapdragon 8 Gen 3, 12 GB RAM | Display: 6.36 inches (16.15 cm), FHD+, LTPO AMOLED, 120 Hz Refresh Rate | Camera: 50 MP + 50 MP + 50 MP Triple Primary Cameras, Dual-color LED Flash, 32 MP Front Camera | Battery: 4610 mAh Hyper Charging, USB Type-C Port

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